

Course Report

SK1127: Conflict and Conflict Resolution

Spring Semester 2025

Magnus Lundgren

1. Background

The course is the second course on the International Politics track on the second year of the “Statsvetarprogrammet”. It was offered for the second time. The course provides an introduction study of armed conflict in international politics. It aims to equip students with both theoretical and empirical knowledge about the causes, dynamics, and resolution of armed conflicts. Students are expected to critically analyze academic literature, apply theories to empirical cases, and develop their academic writing skills.

2. Course Content

The course included eight lectures and two seminars, with the seminars structured as interactive simulations to provide students with hands-on experience in conflict bargaining and mediation.

The course content was structured around three key areas. It began with an introduction to key concepts and empirical patterns in armed conflict, covering historical trends and variations in war across different regions. Students explored systemic and dyadic theories of war, focusing on power transitions, alliances, and the security dilemma, before moving on to domestic explanations such as political institutions, economic conditions, and selectorate theory. Individual and organizational-level explanations were also examined, with discussions on leadership, psychology, and bureaucratic decision-making. The second half of the course focused on conflict resolution and strategies for peace. Lectures covered topics such as mediation, sanctions, and peacekeeping operations. The course concluded with a discussion on the future of war, considering long-term trends and technological advancements in conflict.

A significant component of the course was the application of theories to practical scenarios. In the first seminar, students participated in a bargaining simulation designed to illustrate how war can arise due to information asymmetry and incentives to bluff. The second seminar provided a mediation exercise, where students acted as negotiators attempting to resolve a fictional interstate conflict.

The readings combined classic and contemporary literature, including Levy & Thompson’s “Causes of War” and Blattman’s “Why We Fight”, along with supplementary journal articles and case studies. This structure ensured students engaged with both foundational theories and selections of the latest research in conflict studies.

Three teachers were involved in the course. Magnus Lundgren handled lectures, course coordination, and one seminar group, including assessment. Jan Rustemeyer and Leonie Reicheneder handled one seminar group each, including assessment.

3. Students and grade distribution

The course had 37 registered students. Of these, 32 students received a passing grade by July 2025. Of the students who received their grades in the first round, 20 received a passing grade (G) and 12 a pass with distinction (VG).

4. Course evaluation

The course received highly positive feedback from students, with 16 out of 17 respondents (94.1%) rating it as “Very Good” and 5.9% as “Rather Good”. In other words, 100% rated the course favorably. Students particularly appreciated the structured nature of the lectures and the relevance of the readings. Some comments highlighted that the warm-up questions were a useful way to develop into each topic.

The lectures were well-received, with 94.1% of students rating them as “Very Good”, noting their engaging and informative nature. Some students found the pace slightly fast but still valued the content depth and clarity. Similarly, 16 out of 17 respondents (94.1%) rated the teachers as “Very Good”, which also reflects on the quality of the seminar teachers. The course literature was also positively reviewed, though some students found the volume of reading challenging. 52.9% rated the literature as “Very Good” and the rest as “Rather Good”, with many students finding Blattman’s book particularly engaging and accessible while Levy and Thompson was perceived as the more structured of the two.

The seminar simulations appear to have worked very well, with 87.5% rating them as “Very Good” and 12.5% as “Rather Good”. Many students appreciated the simulation approach, finding the bargaining and mediation exercises educational and engaging. Some suggested the second seminar, focused on negotiation, was more useful than the first.

The research paper assignment was generally well-received, with 58.5% rating it as “Very Good” and the rest as “Rather Good”. Students appreciated the flexibility in choosing topics and the structured deadlines, with iterated submissions of the same text, though some suggested that there should be more freedom in selecting explanatory theories.

Course organization, including scheduling and administration on Canvas, was rated by 88.2% of students as “Very Good”, with comments highlighting the ease of access to course materials and information.

Regarding workload, 76.5% of students found it “OK”, while 23.5% found it “Not that demanding”, but no comments suggest what was less-than-demanding so it is difficult to assess the sources of this.

Finally, 82.4% of responding students reported that they learnt “a great deal” from the course, whereas the remainder learnt “a fair amount”. No students learned “a little” or “almost nothing”. As the course coordinator, I rate this as the most important metric, and I was heartened that it was both high and had increased from the previous semester.

5. Possible changes in the next round

Overall, the course was well-received and functioned quite well, organizationally and substantively, so the structure and content of the course will not change dramatically.

However, in the fall semester 2025, there will be two changes to the course, in response to contextual developments. First, due to a reduction of budgeted hours for the course, lecture 8 on the future of war will be put on pause, and the course will therefore include only seven lectures. Second, due to the dramatic increase in student's reliance on AI, we will add an mini oral exam complementing the research paper assignment.

Appendix: Student evaluation

SK1127 V25 Conflict and conflict resolution

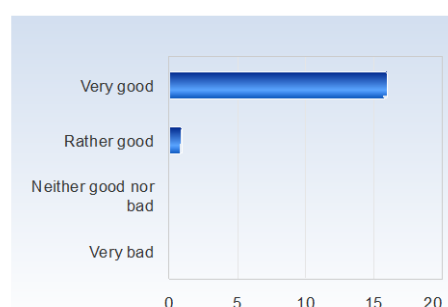
Respondents: 38

Answer Count: 17

Answer Frequency: 44.74%

Overall, how would you assess the course?

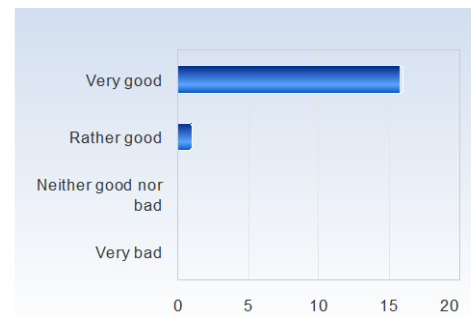
Overall, how would you assess the course?	Number of responses
Very good	16 (94.1%)
Rather good	1 (5.9%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	17 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the course?	1.1	0.2	22.9 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0

Overall, how would you assess the lectures?

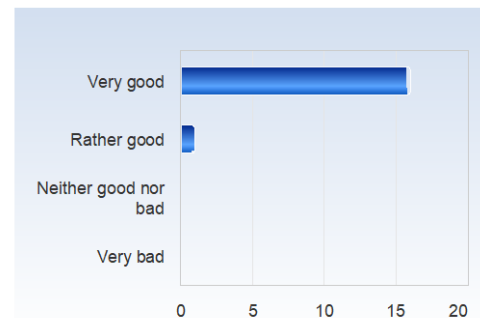
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	Number of responses
Very good	16 (94.1%)
Rather good	1 (5.9%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	17 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	1.1	0.2	22.9 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0

Overall, how would you assess the teachers?

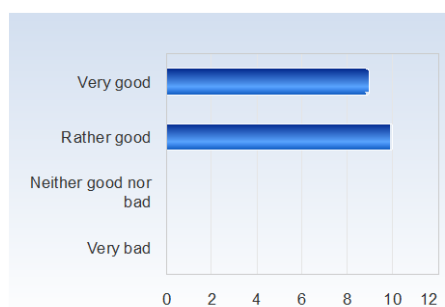
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	Number of responses
Very good	16 (94.1%)
Rather good	1 (5.9%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	17 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	1.1	0.2	22.9 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0

Overall, how would you assess the literature?

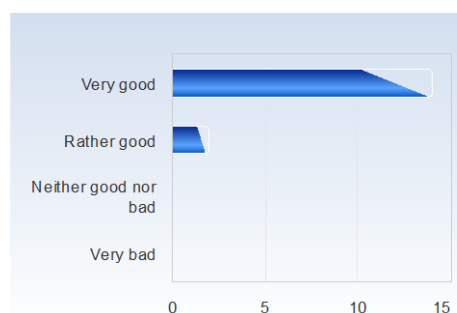
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	Number of responses
Very good	9 (52.9%)
Rather good	10 (58.8%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (111.8%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	1.5	0.5	33.6 %	1.0	1.0	2.0	2.0	2.0

Overall, how would you assess the seminars?

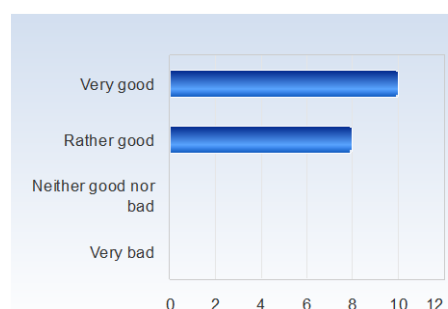
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	Number of responses
Very good	14 (87.5%)
Rather good	2 (12.5%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	16 (100.0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	1.1	0.3	30.4 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0

Overall, how would you assess the course research paper assignment?

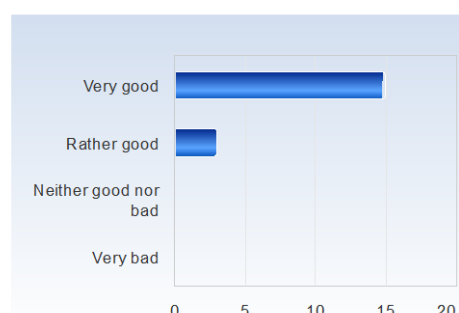
Overall, how would you assess the course research paper assignment?	Number of responses
Very good	10 (58.8%)
Rather good	8 (47.1%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	18 (105.9%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the course research paper assignment?	1.4	0.5	35.4 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0	2.0

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (informations, schedule, administration)?

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (informations, schedule, administration)?	Number of responses
Very good	15 (88.2%)
Rather good	3 (17.6%)
Neither good nor bad	0 (0.0%)
Very bad	0 (0.0%)
Total	18 (105.9%)

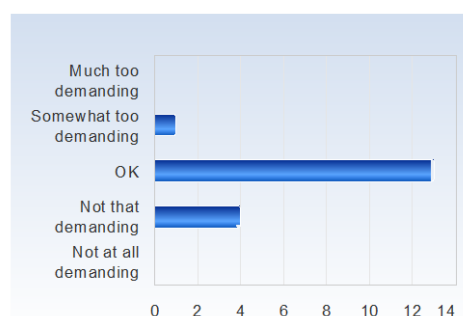


	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (informations, schedule, administration)?	1.2	0.4	32.9 %	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.0	2.0

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:

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	Number of responses
Much too demanding	0 (0.0%)
Somewhat too demanding	1 (5.9%)
OK	13 (76.5%)
Not that demanding	4 (23.5%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0.0%)
Total	18 (105.9%)

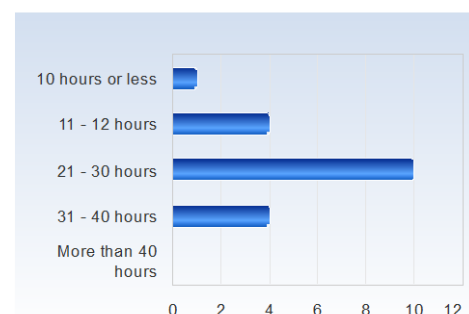


	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	3.2	0.5	16.2 %	2.0	3.0	3.0	3.0	4.0

Please estimate how many hours, per week, you have spent on studying during the course?

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	Number of responses
10 hours or less	1 (5.9%)
11 - 12 hours	4 (23.5%)
21 - 30 hours	10 (58.8%)
31 - 40 hours	4 (23.5%)
More than 40 hours	0 (0.0%)
Total	19 (111.8%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Please estimate how many hours, per week, you have spent on studying during the course?	2.9	0.8	28.0 %	1.0	2.5	3.0	3.0	4.0

Comment

The research paper writing required a lot more time than the previous weeks and parts

How much did you learn during the course?

How much did you learn during the course?	Number of responses
A great deal	14 (82.4%)
A fair amount	3 (17.6%)
A little	0 (0.0%)
Almost nothing	0 (0.0%)
Total	17 (100.0%)

